

ACOG Patient Education Guidelines: Common Pregnancy Discomforts and Symptoms

1. Swollen Feet and Ankles (Edema):

Swollen feet and ankles are common in pregnancy due to increased blood volume and pressure on the pelvic veins. Relief measures include elevating feet above heart level, wearing comfortable shoes, avoiding standing for long periods, staying hydrated, and wearing compression socks.

2. Morning Sickness (Nausea and Vomiting):

Affects up to 80% of pregnant women, primarily in the first trimester. Recommendations include eating small, frequent meals, keeping dry crackers by the bed, avoiding greasy or spicy foods, taking ginger supplements (up to 1g per day), and vitamin B6 (pyridoxine) therapy.

3. Back Pain:

Common due to center-of-gravity shifts and hormone relaxin loosening ligaments. Remedies include practicing good posture, wearing supportive flat shoes, using a pregnancy pillow for sleeping on the side, applying warm compresses, and doing gentle stretches.

4. When Discomfort is a Red Flag:

Mild swelling or nausea is normal. However, sudden severe swelling in the hands or face, accompanied by severe headache or vision changes, can be a sign of pre-eclampsia and requires immediate evaluation.